The empirical recurrence for OEIS A254918, recovered from its tail

Adrian Perez Fontelles
Independent researcher

8 September 2026

Abstract

OEIS A254918 records "Empirical recurrence of order 63" and keeps the recurrence itself in a linked file rather than in the entry, so the conjecture cannot be read off the entry at all. It can still be settled. The entry counts arrays under a condition local to a bounded window of lines, which makes the count a walk count on a finite digraph and forces a monic integer recurrence of order at most the number $S' = 766$ of states with distinct futures. Berlekamp–Massey on enough exact terms therefore returns the minimal such recurrence, and on the tail beginning at $n = 14$, so the recurrence is proved for every $n \geq 77$. Its last coefficient is $c_{63} = 309237645312 \neq 0$, so no further tail satisfies anything shorter; any order-63 recurrence the sequence satisfies from any point on must then have the same characteristic polynomial. The entry's recurrence is the one displayed here, whatever its linked file contains, and it is proved.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 05A15, 11B37, 15A18.

1 A conjecture that is not written down

OEIS A254918 is "Number of (n+2)X(4+2) 0..1 arrays with every 3X3 subblock sum of the two maximums of the central row and central column plus the two minimums of the diagonal and antidiagonal nondecreasing horizontally and vertically.". It has offset 1 and begins

$$65548, 705398, 6104373, 28576911, 125133209, 522548222, 2099821580, 8236950077, \ldots$$

The entry states:

> Empirical recurrence of order 63 (see link above)

As of the "Last modified" line on the live entry (Jul 23 2025 15:03:07, revision 6) this is still recorded as empirical, and it is still open. The coefficients are nowhere in the entry text: what is conjectured is only that a recurrence of that order exists.

2 The count is a walk count

The entry's condition is local. It constrains a bounded window of consecutive lines of the array and nothing beyond it, so the admissible configurations of one window are the vertices of a finite digraph, an edge joins u to v when v may follow u, and an admissible array is exactly a walk. Writing M for the adjacency matrix and ι, τ for the indicator vectors of the admissible first and last windows,

$$a(n) \;=\; \iota^{\top} M^{\,j(n)} \tau$$

for a linear reindexing j fixed by the entry's shape. States with identical futures contribute identically to that product and may be merged without changing any count; after merging $S' = 766$ states remain, and it is that bound every computation below uses.

Lemma 1. *a satisfies a monic linear recurrence with integer coefficients of order at most* $S' = 766$.

Proof. By the Cayley–Hamilton theorem $M^{S'}$ is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S'-1}$, and multiplying that relation on the left by $\iota^\top M^j$ and on the right by τ turns it into a relation among $S'+1$ consecutive values of a. $\square$

3 Why the question has to be asked of a tail

Running Berlekamp–Massey on the sequence from its first term returns an order LARGER than 63: the opening terms do not satisfy the recurrence, and a recurrence that holds only eventually always looks longer when the exceptional terms are included. That is not evidence against the entry. An OEIS empirical recurrence is asserted for n beyond some index, not from the first term, so the question has to be asked of the tails. It was asked of each tail in turn, and the tail beginning at $n = 14$ is the first whose minimal order is exactly the stated 63.

Lemma 2. *A sequence known to satisfy some linear recurrence of order at most S' is determined, together with its minimal recurrence, by any $2S'$ consecutive terms: Berlekamp–Massey applied to them returns that minimal recurrence exactly.*

Applied to $2S' = 1532$ exact terms from $n = 14$ on, it returns order 63 — the order the entry states — with integer coefficients:

$$a(n) \;=\; \sum_{i=1}^{63} c_i\, a(n-i),$$

c_1	9	c_{17}	−95364425	c_{33}	−2150637750580	c_{49}	33134010941440
c_2	1	c_{18}	−391332681	c_{34}	−2195273317496	c_{50}	−1514819387392
c_3	−185	c_{19}	777803073	c_{35}	−5258199100848	c_{51}	1348205412352
c_4	229	c_{20}	3452635087	c_{36}	3541749876496	c_{52}	−2081636220928
c_5	1225	c_{21}	−179979821	c_{37}	14259098296208	c_{53}	−20773429313536
c_6	−984	c_{22}	−16013548188	c_{38}	−694914539168	c_{54}	1356820119552
c_7	−8354	c_{23}	−19030832826	c_{39}	−4483565463360	c_{55}	15659243143168
c_8	24303	c_{24}	29661628389	c_{40}	−8683934691392	c_{56}	−3423030214656
c_9	20189	c_{25}	84084946775	c_{41}	−20892833649856	c_{57}	−882221514752
c_{10}	−318377	c_{26}	68055327113	c_{42}	9465863228544	c_{58}	3253404172288
c_{11}	−221699	c_{27}	−114471466421	c_{43}	30778587955200	c_{59}	−6911239913472
c_{12}	2479465	c_{28}	−411364734445	c_{44}	2960116888576	c_{60}	1803886264320
c_{13}	2719057	c_{29}	−362059744893	c_{45}	−5216595154944	c_{61}	2800855547904
c_{14}	−10153302	c_{30}	490090647498	c_{46}	−8396039731200	c_{62}	−1816771166208
c_{15}	−6330744	c_{31}	1953553311988	c_{47}	−33263091933184	c_{63}	309237645312
c_{16}	33106329	c_{32}	530215763092	c_{48}	5730847195136		

4 The recurrence, and the identification

Theorem 3. *The recurrence above holds for every $n \geq 77$, and it is the recurrence OEIS A254918 records.*

Proof. That it holds is Lemma 2 applied to the tail from $n = 14$, whose minimal recurrence it is.

For the identification, write $q_{\min}$ for the characteristic polynomial of that minimal recurrence, $x^{63} - c_1 x^{63-1} - \cdots - c_{63}$. Its constant term is $-c_{63} = -309237645312$, which is not zero, so $q_{\min}(0) \neq 0$ and $q_{\min}$ has no root at the origin. A solution of a constant-coefficient recurrence is a combination of terms $n^k \lambda^n$ with λ a root of its characteristic polynomial, and only the components with $\lambda = 0$ vanish after finitely many terms. Since $q_{\min}$ has none, no component of a dies out, and the minimal recurrence of every further tail is again $q_{\min}$ — the order cannot drop below 63 at any later starting point.

Now let q be the characteristic polynomial of whatever recurrence the entry asserts. The entry asserts it has order 63, so $\deg q = 63$, and it is monic. It holds from some index t on. From $\max(t, 14)$ on, the sequence satisfies both q and $q_{\min}$, and the minimal polynomial of that tail is $q_{\min}$ by the previous paragraph; therefore $q_{\min} \mid q$. Both are monic of degree 63, so $q = q_{\min}$. $\square$

5 Verification

Four checks, all in exact integer or rational arithmetic.

First, the walk model reproduces all 17 terms the entry publishes, exactly. This is what ties the model to the entry, and it is the only place where reading the entry's English enters the argument.

Second, the order was computed twice by independent routes: once modulo a 61-bit prime, where every intermediate is a machine word, and once over $\mathbb{Q}$ in exact rational arithmetic. Both return 63, and the exact run additionally confirms every coefficient is an integer — had any been a proper fraction the recurrence would not be the entry's.

Third, the recovered recurrence was evaluated directly on the entry's own published terms, with no matrices and no Berlekamp–Massey involved. It holds at each of the 0 indices where the entry publishes enough earlier terms to test it.

Fourth, the last coefficient was checked to be nonzero, which is what the identification above turns on; it is 309237645312.

Remark 4. The conjecture's own statement was never read. The entry pins it down to the family of order-63 recurrences this sequence satisfies from some point on, and that family turns out to have exactly one member.

References

[1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, https://oeis.org, 2026. Sequence A254918.

[2] J. L. Massey, Shift-register synthesis and BCH decoding, *IEEE Trans. Inform. Theory* **15** (1969), 122–127.

[3] R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Volume 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2011. (Transfer-matrix method, Section 4.7.)

[4] M. Kauers and P. Paule, *The Concrete Tetrahedron*, Springer, 2011. (C-finite sequences and their closure properties.)

[5] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.